

So, AI 'wastes' water. But... how?

Posted by u/Level-Pause9643 • • 0 points • 3 comments

Okay, so here's my thought process. AI uses/wastes water to use for cooling, right? Makes sense, since water is OP when it comes to cooling stuff down. BUT, that just makes the water evaporate, right? So why couldn't the companies just let the water re-form and re-use the same water? And, follow up question--isn't a TON of generating power, such as nuclear energy, basically used to heat water up and use steam to transfer it to kinetic energy? So why couldn't they do the same thing with the water used to cool AI stuff? It probably wouldn't fully cover the energy that the AI uses, but it would reduce it at least.

I'm against generative AI that steals from people, but I've never understood the 'wasted' water argument. Please inform me and cure my small brain! Thank you!!!

Comments

u/Moogatron88 • 1 points • 2026-03-19 00:56 UTC

Building a closed-loop like that would require a significant investment in infrastructure that companies aren't willing to shell out on, or aren't able to.

Some areas also have regulatory issues that make doing it tricky to navigate.

u/NoStupidQuestionsBot • 1 points • 2026-03-19 00:54 UTC

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u/CinderrUwU • 1 points • 2026-03-19 00:53 UTC

They can't keep the same water just going around and around. A closed loop system just... really isn't efficient. It takes so much maintenance and technical and monitoring that for most AI centers it just isn't worth it, and even then it will still take up water due to leaks or needing it replaced due to impurities.

And well... data centers aren't hot enough to evaporate enough water to make any meaningful energy.